

WHOSE LEGACY? A JJP poster, showing Dushyant with family icons, that angered INLD's Abhay (below)



HARYANA

A DYNASTIC DIN

The fragmented Chautala brood fights over his Jat legacy, but it's a grim hedge against irrelevance

By **Anilesh S. Mahajan**

REMINISCENT OF THE competing claims on Bal Thackeray by the two Shiv Senas, a *dangal* is unfolding in Haryana's heartland. At stake is a face—that of Jat patriarch Om Prakash Chautala. It's not even been six months since the ex-CM's demise. But just like farmland gets fragmented as families grow and drift apart, the son of the iconic Devi Lal has become the subject of a family feud: on who gets to use his turbaned visage as a heraldic emblem.

Both the legacy party, son Abhay Chautala's Indian National Lok Dal (INLD), and the splinter Jannayak Janta Party (JJP) of grandson Dushyant Chautala, lay claim to his political estate—image, sway, electoral turf.

Takeaways

- **Dushyant's JJP and Abhay's INLD fight over who is the real Chautala political heir**
- **Neither was able to leave a mark in 2024 assembly poll, heredity may not build future**

On May 17, the JJP said Chautala's face would adorn its posters. The INLD reacted sharply. "You have no right to appropriate his legacy after betraying it," Abhay thundered. "We are his blood," Dushyant fired back, "we honour his vision." The heated words frame a larger source of desperation: both sides are fighting for relevance in a state where their influence is rapidly waning.

Look no further than the 2024 assembly election. The JJP had a pristine tally of zero; Dushyant, ex-deputy CM, finished fifth in his seat. The INLD barely bettered that, with just two seats in Sirsa. Upshot: beyond that home turf, the magic is fast fading.

Chautala had seen this coming. The 2018 family split had left him heartbroken—he tried to make peace, and eventually sided with his son, seeing Dushyant's exit as a betrayal. But voters see this as a tired soap opera: young Jats prefer the BJP over sub-regional politics. If the Chautalas have one hope, it's the Congress's shambolic state. Ex-CM Bhupinder Singh Hooda's age and tenuous rapport with New Delhi present an opening. But instead of party work, much less ideology, the Chautalas are relying on nostalgia. ■

By **Kavitha Muralidharan**

IN TIMES when historical controversies can raise enough dust to bury entire civilisations, the ancient Tamil site of Keezhadi has re-emerged as a flashpoint. The Archaeological Survey of India (ASI) has asked the site's lead archaeologist to revise his final report of January 2023—essentially, to locate the site on a much later timeline than the 6th-8th century BC originally suggested by the evidence.

This has sparked fresh allegations of political interference in historical research. 'Post-dating' the site would take away all the excitement from a discovery that had conferred greater civilisational depth to Tamil Nadu, pushing back its Sangam era by three centuries.



